now, Max?" Ausable asked. "If I do not answer the door, they will enter anyway. The door is unlocked. And they will not hesitate to shoot." Max's face was black with anger as he backed swiftly towards the window. He swung a leg over the **sill**. "Send them away!" he warned. "I will wait on the balcony. Send them away or I'll shoot and take my chances!" The knocking at the door became louder and a voice was raised.



Keeping his body twisted so that his gun still covered the fat man and his guest, the man at the window grasped the frame with his free hand to support himself. Then he swung his other leg up and over the window-sill. The doorknob turned. Swiftly Max pushed with his left hand to free himself from the sill and drop to the balcony. And then, as he dropped, he screamed once, shrilly. The door opened and a waiter stood there with a tray, a bottle and two glasses.

"Here is the drink you ordered when you returned," he said, and set the tray on the table, **deftly** uncorked the bottle, and left the room. White-faced, Fowler stared after him. "But..." he stammered, "the police..." "There were no police." Ausable sighed. "Only Henry, whom I was expecting." "But won't that man out on the balcony…?" Fowler began. "No," said Ausable, "he won't return. You see, my young friend, there is no balcony."

About The Author



Robert Jay Arthur Jr. (November 10, 1909 – May 2, 1969) was a writer of speculative fiction and specialised in crime fiction, and mystery fiction. He was known for his work with *The Mysterious Traveler radio series* and for writing *The Three Investigators*, a series of young adult novels. Arthur was honoured twice by the Mystery Writers of America with an Edgar Award for Best Radio Drama. He also wrote scripts for television.

Glossary

musty - having a stale smell

wheezily - with a hissing sound while breathing

espionage - the practice of spying to obtain information

sloppy - careless and unsystematic

prosaic - ordinary, usual

inflection - modulation, intonation

sill - a slab of wood or stone at the foot of a window opening or doorway

deftly - skillfully

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